Cautionary Notes

V-Dem is firmly committed to full transparency and release of our data. Therefore, we ask users to take the following cautionary notes into consideration when using our data.

- The *V-Dem measurement model*, which we use to aggregate expert-coded data, assumes that each country-year-variable has five or more coders. For a few country-year-variables – and especially in the context of countries with a small population – it has been impossible to achieve this target. Country-year-variable combinations with fewer than five expert coders are more likely to show substantial changes in their point estimates than countries with five or more coders, since individual expert changes have more weight in these contexts. Unfortunately, these changes may be more extreme than the actual changes in the latent concept the variable is intended to measure. We therefore strongly advise against using point estimates for country-year-variable combinations with three or fewer coders. To allow users to filter these observations out of the dataset we provide a variable with the suffix "_nr" (number of raters/coders), which provides the count of experts for each country-year-variable combination.
  - We have already removed observations for *Exclusion* and *Legitimation* indicators (section 3.14 and section 3.15) with less than three coders per country-date (*_nr < 3). Furthermore, we have removed observations in *Exclusion indices* (section 5.6) where less than three component country-year-variables had three or more coders.
  - We have removed observations for *Civic and Academic Space* indicators (section 3.16) with less than 3 coders per country-date (*_nr < 3).
- Point estimates can jump around slightly across iterations of the dataset due to the simulation-based nature of the estimation process and expert turnover. Consumers of the data should therefore always be attentive to the uncertainty about the estimates. Indeed, this uncertainty provides vital information about the degree to which one can be certain that a change in a score reflects an actual change in the level of the concept being measured.
- We advise caution when using variables that had convergence issues. Please see individual codebook entries for additional information. For details on interpreting convergence information, please refer to *Variable Entry Clarifications* (section 1.4.5), the Methodology Document, and Pemstein et al. (2026).
  - The following variables had issues with convergence in v16:
    v2caautmob, v2caconmob, v2caviol, v2cltrnslw, v2csgender, v2dlencmps, v2eldonate, v2elpaidig, v2elpdcamp, v2elpubfin, v2elrgstry, v2exdjcbhg, v2exdjdshg, v2peedueq, v2pepwrses, v2pscohesv, v2psprlnks, v2regoppgroupssize, v2smforads, v2smonper, v2x_cspart, v2xeg_eqaccess, v2xeg_eqdr.
- We do not account for variation in expert reliability or scale perception when estimating values for percentage variables. As a result, expert error such as miscoding can result in substantial changes to the estimates of these variables irrespective of actual changes in the constructs they represent. We therefore recommend that users exercise caution when interpreting the three percentage variables:
  - Female journalists (v2mefemjrn)
  - State authority over territory (v2svstterr)
  - Weaker civil liberties population (v2clsnlpct)
- We constantly improve the coding of factual data (A) to make it as accurate as possible. This may result in changes at the index-level.
- *Historical V-Dem:* We advise users to exercise caution before running analysis on the time series extending across both the historical and contemporary coding periods. Specifically, we note an issue with Historical V-Dem A-type variables. In the historical part of the time series, one or more coders conducted the historical part of the time series independently of the existing coding in the V-Dem dataset. This practice extended to the overlap period with the contemporary V-Dem time series (typically 1900-1920).

For many of these historical variables, we have checked the consistency of the coding, further scrutinized the sources, and determined which coding represents the most appropriate score after deliberation. We have subsequently made the appropriate adjustments to the data. For other historical A variables we have yet to finalize this process. For these variables, the scores reported for the overlap period in the dataset are the contemporary V-Dem scores by default. This coding decision means that in the case of countries where there is disagreement between the historical and contemporary coding in the starting year for the contemporary time series (typically 1900)[1], there may be artificial changes between that year and the year before that do not necessarily reflect a real-world change in the political system in the country.

Please also note that for the variables where there is not full correspondence between the historical (1789-1920) and contemporary (1900-2025) coding, we also provide the historical coding of the variables in their original form as separate variables, carrying a "v3" rather than a "v2" prefix on the variable tag. These "v3" variables can be found in a separate section of the codebook.

[1] For more information on the coding years coverage for each country, see the V-Dem *Country Coding Unit* document.